Power Sums, a Recurrence Basis, and Substitution Identities

Contents

1 Setup **2**

2 Weighted Power Sums **2**

3 The Basis K, L, M **3**
3.1 Definition via the antisymmetric weights 3

4 The Decomposition Theorem **4**

5 Applications and Key Lemmas **4**
5.1 Newton's identity: $s_n = x^n + y^n + z^n$ 4

6 Generalised K and Substitution Identities **5**
6.1 The generalised function $K_n(a, b, c)$ 5
6.2 The squaring substitution: $(a, b, c) = (x^2, y^2, z^2)$ 5

7 General Power Substitution **6**

8 An Addition Formula for K **7**

9 Consequences of $s_n = 0$ over the reals **8**

10 Constraints on a hypothetical FLT counter-example **9**

11 Shifted Divisibility Under the Fermat Assumption **10**
11.1 Bounding $d = \gcd(K(n),\, K(n+1))$ 11

12 The Bound $K(n) \mid 18$ **13**
12.1 Symmetric polynomials of the n-th powers 13
12.2 Two divisibility conditions on $K(n)$ 14
12.3 The main bound 14

Introduction

This note develops a self-contained algebraic framework for power sums $s_n = x^n + y^n + z^n$ and their relatives. The central object is a sequence $K(n)$ built from the antisymmetric weights of x, y, z; together with two companion sequences L and M, it forms a basis for all sequences satisfying the same linear recurrence as the power sums.

All arguments use only the recurrence and elementary algebra; no advanced number theory or analysis is required.

1 Setup

Throughout, x, y, z are distinct and nonzero complex (or real) numbers. We write their elementary symmetric polynomials as

$$e_1 = x + y + z, \qquad e_2 = xy + yz + zx, \qquad e_3 = xyz,$$

and define the *minimal polynomial*

$$P(t) = t^3 - e_1 t^2 + e_2 t - e_3 = (t - x)(t - y)(t - z).$$

Since $e_3 = xyz \neq 0$ we may divide by any power of x, y, or z, and in particular extend all recurrences to all integers $n \in \mathbb{Z}$.

Cyclic sum notation

Many expressions in this paper are cyclic in x, y, z. We write

$$[g(x)]_{\text{cyc}} \;:=\; g(x) + g(y) + g(z)$$

for the cyclic sum of any expression g, where the implicit substitution rule is $x \to y \to z \to x$. For example, $e_1 = [x]_{\text{cyc}}$, $e_2 = [xy]_{\text{cyc}}$, $e_3 = xyz$, and more usefully:

$$[x^n(y - z)]_{\text{cyc}} \;=\; x^n(y - z) + y^n(z - x) + z^n(x - y).$$

This notation eliminates the need to write all three terms of any cyclic identity.

2 Weighted Power Sums

Definition 2.1. For any integer n and a weight triple (k, l, m), define

$$f_n(k, l, m) = kx^n + ly^n + mz^n = [k\, x^n]_{\text{cyc}}\,,$$

where in the cyclic notation it is understood that the weights cycle as $(k, l, m) \to (l, m, k)$ alongside $(x, y, z) \to (y, z, x)$.

Special cases of immediate interest:

$$s_n \;:=\; f_n(1,1,1) \;=\; x^n + y^n + z^n \;=\; [x^n]_{\text{cyc}}\,.$$

The key properties of f_n are linearity in weights and the universal recurrence inherited from $P(t)$.

Theorem 2.2 (Recurrence)**.** *For any fixed weights (k,l,m) and any integer n,*

$$f_{n+3}(k,l,m) = e_1\, f_{n+2}(k,l,m) - e_2\, f_{n+1}(k,l,m) + e_3\, f_n(k,l,m).$$

Proof. Each of x, y, z satisfies $t^3 = e_1 t^2 - e_2 t + e_3$. Multiply by t^n, weight by k, l, m respectively, and sum. □

Because $e_3 \neq 0$ the recurrence can also be run backwards, making $f_n(k,l,m)$ well-defined for all $n \in \mathbb{Z}$.

3 The Basis K, L, M

Any sequence satisfying the recurrence of Theorem 2.2 is determined by its values at three consecutive integers. We single out the three basis sequences with initial values forming the identity matrix at $n = 0, 1, 2$.

3.1 Definition via the antisymmetric weights

The triple of *difference weights*

$$(w_x,\, w_y,\, w_z) \;:=\; (y-z,\; z-x,\; x-y)$$

satisfies $w_x + w_y + w_z = 0$ and is nonzero since x, y, z are distinct. A short computation gives

$$f_0(w_x, w_y, w_z) = 0, \quad f_1(w_x, w_y, w_z) = 0, \quad f_2(w_x, w_y, w_z) = \big[x^2(y-z)\big]_{\text{cyc}} =: \Delta,$$

where $\Delta = -(y-z)(z-x)(x-y) \neq 0$. (The f_2 identity follows by straightforward algebra, or see Section 6.)

Definition 3.1. For any integer n, define

$$K(n) \;=\; \frac{f_n(w_x,\, w_y,\, w_z)}{\Delta} \;=\; \frac{[x^n(y-z)]_{\text{cyc}}}{[x^2(y-z)]_{\text{cyc}}}.$$

Definition 3.2.

$$L(n) = K(n+1) - e_1\, K(n), \qquad M(n) = e_3\, K(n-1).$$

The initial values follow immediately:

n	0	1	2
$K(n)$	0	0	1
$L(n)$	0	1	0
$M(n)$	1	0	0

The triple (K, L, M) forms the *standard basis* for all integer sequences satisfying the recurrence: the columns at $n = 0, 1, 2$ are exactly the identity matrix. All three sequences satisfy the same recurrence as f_n, since K inherits it from f_n, and L, M are linear combinations of shifts of K.

Remark 3.3. The explicit values of K at small n are $K(2) = 1$, $K(3) = e_1$, $K(4) = e_1^2 - e_2$, and so on; L and M are recovered from K via the definitions above. The backward extension gives $K(-1) = 1/e_3$, consistent with $M(0) = e_3 K(-1) = 1$.

4 The Decomposition Theorem

The following is the central engine of everything that follows.

Theorem 4.1 (Decomposition)**.** *For any weights (k, l, m) and any integer n,*

$$f_n(k, l, m) \;=\; K(n)\, f_2(k, l, m) \;+\; L(n)\, f_1(k, l, m) \;+\; M(n)\, f_0(k, l, m).$$

Proof. Both sides satisfy the same recurrence. They agree at $n = 0, 1, 2$ by the initial values of K, L, M. Uniqueness of recurrence solutions gives equality for all n. □

Corollary 4.2 (Shift invariance)**.** *For any weights (k, l, m) and any integers n, j,*

$$f_{n+j}(k, l, m) \;=\; K(n)\, f_{j+2}(k, l, m) \;+\; L(n)\, f_{j+1}(k, l, m) \;+\; M(n)\, f_j(k, l, m).$$

Proof. Fix j. The shifted sequence $h_n = f_{n+j}(k, l, m)$ satisfies the same recurrence, with $h_0 = f_j$, $h_1 = f_{j+1}$, $h_2 = f_{j+2}$. Apply Theorem 4.1 to h_n. □

The Decomposition Theorem says: *to evaluate any weighted power sum at index n, it suffices to know it at three consecutive indices — and the coefficients are always $K(n)$, $L(n)$, $M(n)$, regardless of the weights.*

5 Applications and Key Lemmas

5.1 Newton's identity: $s_n = x^n + y^n + z^n$

Apply the decomposition with weights $(1, 1, 1)$, noting $f_0(1, 1, 1) = 3$, $f_1(1, 1, 1) = e_1$, $f_2(1, 1, 1) = e_1^2 - 2e_2$:

$$s_n \;=\; K(n)\,(e_1^2 - 2e_2) \;+\; L(n)\, e_1 \;+\; 3\, M(n).$$

In particular, $s_0 = 3$, $s_1 = e_1$, $s_2 = e_1^2 - 2e_2$ match the known Newton values, and equality for all n follows. Expanding the definitions yields the key formula:

Lemma 5.1. $s_n = e_1K(n+1) - 2e_2K(n) + 3e_3K(n-1)$ *for all integers* n.

Proof. Apply the Decomposition Theorem with weights $(1,1,1)$, substituting $f_0(1,1,1) = 3$, $f_1(1,1,1) = e_1$, $f_2(1,1,1) = e_1^2 - 2e_2$ and the definitions $L(n) = K(n+1) - e_1K(n)$, $M(n) = e_3K(n-1)$:

$$s_n = K(n)(e_1^2-2e_2)+L(n)\,e_1+3M(n) = K(n)(e_1^2-2e_2)+(K(n+1)-e_1K(n))e_1+3e_3K(n-1).$$

Expanding and cancelling the $e_1^2K(n)$ terms gives the result. □

Theorem 5.2. $s_n = K(n+2) + L(n+1) + M(n)$ *for all integers* n.

Proof. By Lemma 5.1, $s_n = e_1K(n+1) - 2e_2K(n) + 3e_3K(n-1)$. Substituting $K(n+2) = e_1K(n+1)-e_2K(n)+e_3K(n-1)$, $L(n+1) = K(n+2)-e_1K(n+1)$, and $M(n) = e_3K(n-1)$, one verifies that $K(n+2)+L(n+1)+M(n) = e_1K(n+1)-2e_2K(n)+3e_3K(n-1) = s_n$. □

6 Generalised K and Substitution Identities

6.1 The generalised function $K_n(a,b,c)$

The formula in Definition 3.1 makes sense for any distinct nonzero triple (a,b,c).

Definition 6.1. For distinct nonzero a,b,c and any integer n,

$$K_n(a,b,c) \;=\; \frac{[a^n(b-c)]_{\text{cyc}}}{[a^2(b-c)]_{\text{cyc}}} \;=\; \frac{a^n(b-c)+b^n(c-a)+c^n(a-b)}{-(b-c)(c-a)(a-b)}.$$

So $K_n(x,y,z) = K(n)$. The function $K_n(a,b,c)$ satisfies the recurrence with symmetric polynomials ε_i of (a,b,c) in place of e_i, and has initial values $K_0 = K_1 = 0$, $K_2 = 1$ for any admissible triple.

The power of this definition is that *evaluating K_n at a specific triple reduces, via the Decomposition Theorem, to a clean identity in K, L, M.* The next three subsections illustrate this with the three most natural substitutions.

6.2 The squaring substitution: $(a,b,c) = (x^2,y^2,z^2)$

The triple (x^2,y^2,z^2) has symmetric polynomials

$$\varepsilon_1 = e_1^2 - 2e_2, \qquad \varepsilon_2 = e_2^2 - 2e_1e_3, \qquad \varepsilon_3 = e_3^2.$$

Theorem 6.2 (Squaring-substitution identity)**.** *For all integers* n,

$$(e_3 - e_1e_2)\cdot K_n(x^2,\,y^2,\,z^2) \;=\; L(2n).$$

Proof. This is the special case $k = 2$ of Theorem 7.1 in Section 7, proved there in full. We verify the prefactor: $\Delta_2/\Delta = (x+y)(y+z)(z+x) = -(e_3-e_1e_2)$, and at $k = 2$ the right-hand side of Theorem 7.1 is $K(2n)\,K(3) - K(2n+1)\,K(2) = e_1K(2n) - K(2n+1) = -L(2n)$, since $K(2) = 1$, $K(3) = e_1$, and $L(2n) = K(2n+1) - e_1K(2n)$. Combining signs gives the stated identity. □

Note $e_3 - e_1e_2 = -(x+y)(y+z)(z+x)$, the product of pairwise sums. To see this, expand $(x+y)(y+z)(z+x) = e_1e_2 - e_3$ directly: the product contributes $xy^2 + y^2z + \cdots$ terms that collect into e_1e_2 and a $-2xyz$ correction that combines with the xyz terms to yield $e_1e_2 - e_3$. In particular the prefactor vanishes if and only if two of x, y, z are negatives of each other, i.e. one pairwise sum is zero.

7 General Power Substitution

For an integer $k \geq 1$, write the *k-th difference discriminant* as

$$\Delta_k \;=\; -(y^k - z^k)(z^k - x^k)(x^k - y^k),$$

consistently with the sign convention $\Delta = \Delta_1 = -(y-z)(z-x)(x-y)$. The ratio Δ_k/Δ is a symmetric polynomial in x, y, z; for example $\Delta_2/\Delta = (x+y)(y+z)(z+x) = -(e_3 - e_1e_2)$.

Theorem 7.1 (General power substitution)**.** *For all integers $k \geq 1$ and n,*

$$\frac{\Delta_k}{\Delta} K_n(x^k, y^k, z^k) \;=\; K(kn)\, K(k+1) - K(kn+1)\, K(k).$$

Proof. By definition, the numerator of $K_n(x^k, y^k, z^k)$ is

$$\left[(x^k)^n (y^k - z^k)\right]_{\text{cyc}} \;=\; f_{kn}(y^k - z^k,\; z^k - x^k,\; x^k - y^k),$$

since $(x^k)^n \cdot (y^k - z^k)$ is the x-term of f_{kn} with weights $(y^k - z^k, z^k - x^k, x^k - y^k)$. Denote these weights (p, q, r). We evaluate f_0, f_1, f_2 at (p, q, r):

- $f_0(p, q, r) = 0$, since $p + q + r = 0$.
- $f_1(p, q, r) \;=\; \left[x(y^k - z^k)\right]_{\text{cyc}}$. Expanding the cyclic sum and collecting the x^k terms (each $x \cdot y^k$ pairs with $-y \cdot x^k$ from the next term): $\left[x(y^k - z^k)\right]_{\text{cyc}} = \left[x^k(z - y)\right]_{\text{cyc}} = -\left[x^k(y - z)\right]_{\text{cyc}} = -K(k)\,\Delta$.
- $f_2(p, q, r) = \left[x^2(y^k - z^k)\right]_{\text{cyc}} = -\left[x^k(y^2 - z^2)\right]_{\text{cyc}}$. Writing $y^2 - z^2 = (y-z)(y+z) = -w_x(y+z)$ and expanding, $\left[x^k(y^2 - z^2)\right]_{\text{cyc}} = e_1\, f_k(w_x, w_y, w_z) - f_{k+1}(w_x, w_y, w_z) = (e_1K(k) - K(k+1))\Delta = -L(k)\,\Delta$, so $f_2(p, q, r) = L(k)\,\Delta$.

Applying the Decomposition Theorem (with kn in place of n):

$$f_{kn}(p, q, r) \;=\; K(kn) \cdot L(k)\,\Delta \;+\; L(kn) \cdot (-K(k))\,\Delta,$$

and since $f_{kn}(p, q, r) = K_n(x^k, y^k, z^k) \cdot \Delta_k$, dividing by Δ:

$$\frac{\Delta_k}{\Delta} K_n(x^k, y^k, z^k) = K(kn)\, L(k) - L(kn)\, K(k).$$

Substituting $L(m) = K(m+1) - e_1K(m)$ into both $L(k)$ and $L(kn)$ and expanding, the e_1 terms cancel, leaving $K(kn)\, K(k+1) - K(kn+1)\, K(k)$. $\square$

Special case $n = 1$

Since $K_1(a, b, c) = 0$ for any triple, the left-hand side vanishes, and the theorem gives $K(k)\,K(k+1) - K(k+1)\,K(k) = 0$: trivially true, and a consistency check.

Special case $n = 2$

Since $K_2(a, b, c) = 1$ for any triple, the theorem gives the closed formula

$$\frac{\Delta_k}{\Delta} \;=\; K(2k)\,K(k+1) - K(2k+1)\,K(k).$$

Special case $n = 3$

For any triple (a, b, c) one has $K_3(a, b, c) = a + b + c$ directly from the closed form: the numerator $[a^3(b-c)]_{\text{cyc}}$ factors as $(a+b+c) \cdot [a^2(b-c)]_{\text{cyc}}$. Applied to (x^k, y^k, z^k) this gives $K_3(x^k, y^k, z^k) = s_k$, and the theorem yields

$$\frac{\Delta_k}{\Delta}\, s_k \;=\; K(3k)\,K(k+1) - K(3k+1)\,K(k).$$

Recovery of the squaring identity (Theorem 6.2)

Set $k = 2$. Then $K(2) = 1$ and $L(2) = K(3) - e_1 K(2) = e_1 - e_1 = 0$, so $K(kn)\,L(k) - L(kn)\,K(k) = -L(2n)$. Since $\Delta_2/\Delta = (x+y)(y+z)(z+x) = -(e_3 - e_1 e_2)$, Theorem 7.1 gives

$$-(e_3 - e_1 e_2) \cdot K_n(x^2, y^2, z^2) \;=\; -L(2n),$$

which is exactly Theorem 6.2.

8 An Addition Formula for K

The following identity is used in Section 10 to relate $K(3n)$ and $K(3n+1)$ to $K(n)$ and $K(n+1)$.

Lemma 8.1 (Addition formula)**.** *For all integers m and n,*

$$K(m+n) \;=\; K(m)\,K(n+1) - e_3\,K(m-1)\,K(n-1) + \big(K(m+1) - e_1 K(m)\big)\,K(n).$$

Equivalently, using $L(m) = K(m+1) - e_1 K(m)$ and $M(m) = e_3 K(m-1)$,

$$K(m+n) \;=\; K(m)\,K(n+1) + L(m)\,K(n) - M(m)\,K(n-1).$$

Proof. Fix m and consider both sides as functions of n. Both satisfy the standard recurrence (in n) with coefficients e_1, e_2, e_3. At $n = 0, 1, 2$ the right-hand side gives, respectively,

$$K(m+0) = K(m), \quad K(m+1), \quad K(m+2),$$

matching the left-hand side. Uniqueness of recurrence solutions (Theorem 4.1) gives equality for all n. $\square$

9 Consequences of $s_n = 0$ over the reals

Throughout this section x, y, z are distinct nonzero real (or complex) numbers satisfying $s_n = x^n + y^n + z^n = 0$ for a fixed integer $n \geq 3$. No integrality is assumed.

The ratio identity

Setting $k = n$ and $m = 3$ in Theorem 7.1 and using $K_3(x^n, y^n, z^n) = s_n = 0$ gives immediately:

Corollary 9.1. *If $s_n = 0$ then $K(3n)\,K(n+1) = K(3n+1)\,K(n)$.*

In other words the two ratios $K(3n)/K(n)$ and $K(3n+1)/K(n+1)$ are equal (whenever the denominators are nonzero). We write their common value $A = K(3n)/K(n)$.

The common ratio A

Theorem 9.2. *If $s_n = 0$ and $K(n) \neq 0$, define $A = K(3n)/K(n)$. Then*

$$K(3n+1) = A\,K(n+1).$$

Proof. The ratio identity (Corollary 9.1) gives $K(3n)\,K(n+1) = K(3n+1)\,K(n)$. Substituting $K(3n) = A\,K(n)$ and dividing both sides by $K(n)$ yields the result. □

The master identity

The two equalities above are the $j = 0$ and $j = 1$ cases of a uniform identity covering every offset j.

Theorem 9.3 (Master identity)**.** *If $s_n = 0$ and $K(n) \neq 0$, then for all integers j,*

$$K(3n+j) \;=\; A\,K(n+j) \;+\; e_3^n\,K(j),$$

where $A = K(3n)/K(n)$.

Proof. Fix n. The right-hand side, viewed as a function of j, is a sum of two sequences: $j \mapsto A\,K(n+j)$ (a scalar multiple of a shift of K) and $j \mapsto e_3^n\,K(j)$ (a scalar multiple of K itself). Both satisfy the recurrence with coefficients e_1, e_2, e_3, and therefore so does their sum. Since the left-hand side also satisfies the same recurrence, it suffices to check agreement at $j = 0, 1, 2$.

$j = 0$: $A\,K(n) + e_3^n \cdot 0 = A\,K(n) = K(3n)$. ✓

$j = 1$: $A\,K(n+1) + e_3^n \cdot 0 = A\,K(n+1) = K(3n+1)$, by Theorem 9.2. ✓

$j = 2$: we need $K(3n+2) = A\,K(n+2) + e_3^n$. Apply the s_n formula (Lemma 5.1) at index $3n$:

$$s_{3n} = e_1\,K(3n+1) - 2e_2\,K(3n) + 3e_3\,K(3n-1).$$

Substituting $K(3n) = A\,K(n)$, $K(3n+1) = A\,K(n+1)$, and using $s_n = 0$ to replace $e_1\,K(n+1) - 2e_2\,K(n) = -3e_3\,K(n-1)$:

$$s_{3n} = 3e_3\,\big(K(3n-1) - A\,K(n-1)\big).$$

Since $x^n + y^n + z^n = 0$, Newton's identity applied to (x^n, y^n, z^n) gives $s_{3n} = 3(xyz)^n = 3e_3^n$, so $K(3n-1) = A\,K(n-1) + e_3^{n-1}$. Now the recurrence at $3n+2$:

$$\begin{aligned} K(3n+2) &= e_1 \cdot A\,K(n+1) - e_2 \cdot A\,K(n) + e_3\,(A\,K(n-1) + e_3^{n-1}) \\ &= A\,\big(e_1\,K(n+1) - e_2\,K(n) + e_3\,K(n-1)\big) + e_3^n = A\,K(n+2) + e_3^n. \quad \checkmark \end{aligned}$$

Uniqueness of recurrence solutions gives equality for all j. □

10 Constraints on a hypothetical FLT counter-example

Disclaimer. Fermat's Last Theorem was proved by Wiles in 1995, and nothing here comes close to an independent proof — nor is that the aim. The goal is to see what arithmetic constraints the framework imposes on a hypothetical primitive solution $x^n + y^n + z^n = 0$ with $x, y, z \in \mathbb{Z}$.

Throughout this section x, y, z are pairwise coprime nonzero integers with $s_n = 0$ and $n \geq 3$ an odd prime. All results of Section 9 apply; in particular the ratio A and the master identity are in force. The additional content here is purely about divisibility.

Divisibility consequences of the master identity

Since x, y, z are integers, every $K(m)$ is an integer. We now show $K(n) \mid K(3n)$, after which divisibility of $K(3n+1)$ and the full master identity follow with no further calculation.

Theorem 10.1. *If x, y, z are coprime integers with $s_n = 0$, then $K(n) \mid K(3n)$, and consequently $K(n+1) \mid K(3n+1)$, with the same integer quotient $A = K(3n)/K(n)$.*

Proof. We show $K(3n) \equiv 0 \pmod{K(n)}$. Applying the addition formula (Lemma 8.1) with $m = n$ and working modulo $K(n)$:

$$\begin{aligned} K(2n) &\equiv L(n)\,K(n+1), \\ K(2n+1) &\equiv L(n)\,K(n+2) + M(n)\,K(n+1), \end{aligned}$$

since every term containing $K(n)$ as a factor vanishes. A further application modulo $K(n)$, substituting $L(n) \equiv K(n+1)$, $M(n) \equiv e_3\,K(n-1)$, and $K(n+2) \equiv e_1\,K(n+1) + e_3\,K(n-1)$, gives

$$K(3n) \;\equiv\; K(n+1)^2\,\big(e_1\,K(n+1) + 3e_3\,K(n-1)\big) \pmod{K(n)}.$$

Since $s_n = 0$, Lemma 5.1 gives $e_1\,K(n+1) + 3e_3\,K(n-1) = 2e_2\,K(n) \equiv 0 \pmod{K(n)}$. Hence $K(3n) \equiv 0 \pmod{K(n)}$, so $A = K(3n)/K(n)$ is an integer.

Since A is an integer, Theorem 9.2 gives $K(3n+1) = A\,K(n+1)$, so $K(n+1) \mid K(3n+1)$ with the same quotient A. □

Since A is an integer, the master identity now takes on its full arithmetic force:

Corollary 10.2 (Master identity over $\mathbb{Z}$)**.** *If x, y, z are pairwise coprime nonzero integers with $s_n = 0$ and $n \geq 3$ an odd prime, then all of $K(m)$, e_3^n, and $A = K(3n)/K(n)$ are integers, and for all integers j,*

$$K(3n+j) \;=\; A\,K(n+j) \;+\; e_3^n\,K(j).$$

In particular, $K(n) \mid K(3n+j) - e_3^n\,K(j)$ for all j.

Proof. Integrality of $K(m)$ follows since $x, y, z \in \mathbb{Z}$. Integrality of A is Theorem 10.1. The identity is Theorem 9.3; divisibility follows immediately. □

The divisibility tower: $K(n) \mid K(mn)$ for all $m \geq 1$

We first record a consequence of the addition formula that requires no assumption on s_n.

Lemma 10.3. *For any distinct nonzero x, y, z and any integer n, $K(n) \mid K(2n)$ unconditionally.*

Proof. Set $m = n$ in the addition formula (Lemma 8.1):

$$K(2n) \;=\; K(n)\,K(n+1) \;+\; L(n)\,K(n) \;-\; M(n)\,K(n-1).$$

Since $L(n) = K(n+1) - e_1K(n)$ and $M(n) = e_3K(n-1)$, substituting gives

$$K(2n) \;=\; K(n)\,\big[2K(n+1) - e_1K(n) - e_3K(n-1)\big].$$

The bracket is an integer whenever x, y, z are integers, so $K(n) \mid K(2n)$. □

Corollary 10.4 (Divisibility tower)**.** *Under the hypotheses of Corollary 10.2 (pairwise coprime integers, $s_n = 0$, $n \geq 3$ an odd prime),*

$$K(n) \;\mid\; K(mn) \qquad \textit{for all integers } m \geq 1.$$

Proof. We induct on m, with the inductive step consuming two previous cases.

Base cases. $m = 1$: trivial. $m = 2$: Lemma 10.3. $m = 3$: Theorem 10.1.

Inductive step. Let $m \geq 4$ and assume the result holds for all positive integers less than m; in particular $K(n) \mid K((m-2)n)$ and $K(n) \mid K((m-3)n)$. Apply the master identity (Corollary 10.2) with $j = (m-3)n$:

$$K(mn) \;=\; K\big(3n + (m-3)n\big) \;=\; A\,K\big((m-2)n\big) \;+\; e_3^n\,K\big((m-3)n\big).$$

Both terms on the right are divisible by $K(n)$ by hypothesis, so $K(n) \mid K(mn)$. □

11 Shifted Divisibility Under the Fermat Assumption

We continue under the standing hypotheses (pairwise coprime integers x, y, z with $s_n = 0$ and $n \geq 3$ an odd prime). We begin by bounding $\gcd(K(n), K(n+1))$, a result needed in the proofs below, and then use it together with the divisibility tower (Corollary 10.4) to obtain divisibility results for the shifted indices $nm + 1$ and $nm + 2$.

11.1 Bounding $d = \gcd(K(n),\, K(n+1))$

Proposition 11.1. *If x, y, z are pairwise coprime nonzero integers with $s_n = 0$ and n an odd prime, then* $\gcd(K(n),\, K(n+1))$ *divides* 3.

Proof. We use the identities

$$s_n = e_1\, K(n+1) - 2e_2\, K(n) + 3e_3\, K(n-1), \tag{1}$$

$$3K(n+2) = 3e_1\, K(n+1) - 3e_2\, K(n) + 3e_3\, K(n-1). \tag{2}$$

Since $s_n = 0$ and $d \mid K(n), K(n+1)$, equation (1) gives

$$d \;\mid\; 3e_3\, K(n-1).$$

Substituting into (2) gives $d \mid 3K(n+2)$. So d divides $3K(n)$, $3K(n+1)$, $3K(n+2)$: three consecutive multiples of 3. Applying the recurrence inductively, $d \mid 3K(m)$ for all $m \geq n$, and in particular $d \mid 3K(2n-1)$, $3K(2n)$, $3K(2n+1)$.

Applying (1) at index $2n$ gives $d \mid s_{2n}$. Since $s_n = 0$,

$$s_{2n} = -2(x^n y^n + y^n z^n + z^n x^n),$$

so

$$d \;\mid\; 2(x^n y^n + y^n z^n + z^n x^n).$$

Parity. Since x, y, z are pairwise coprime with $s_n = 0$, exactly one is even (if all odd then $s_n \equiv 3 \pmod 2 \neq 0$; if two even then they share the factor 2, contradicting coprimeness). Thus e_1, e_3 are even and e_2 is odd. The recurrence mod 2 becomes $K(m+3) \equiv K(m+1) \pmod 2$, giving $K(\text{even}) \equiv 1$, $K(\text{odd}) \equiv 0 \pmod 2$ (by induction from $K(0) = K(1) = 0$, $K(2) = 1$). Since n is odd, $K(n)$ is even and $K(n+1)$ is odd, so $2 \nmid d$.

Let p be any odd prime dividing d and $a = p^k$ the exact power in d.

Case 1: $p \mid e_3 = xyz$**.** Then p divides exactly one of x, y, z, say x. So $a \mid x^n$. In equation (11.1) the terms $x^n y^n$ and $z^n x^n$ vanish mod a, leaving $a \mid 2y^n z^n$. As $\gcd(a, 2) = 1$ and $\gcd(a, y^n z^n) = 1$, we get $a \mid 1$: contradiction.

Case 2: $p \nmid e_3$**.** From (11.1), $a \mid 3e_3 K(n-1)$. Since $p \nmid e_3$, $a \mid 3K(n-1)$. Together with $a \mid 3K(n)$ and $a \mid 3K(n+1)$, backward induction via the rearranged recurrence

$$3e_3 K(m) = 3K(m+3) - 3e_1 K(m+2) + 3e_2 K(m+1)$$

(valid since $p \nmid e_3$) shows $a \mid 3K(m)$ for all $m \leq n$. At $m = 2$: $a \mid 3K(2) = 3$, so $p = 3$ and $k = 1$.

Thus d is odd and every odd prime power in d divides 3, so $d \mid 3$. □

Remark 11.2. Using the exact power $a = p^k$ automatically rules out higher powers such as 9: $p^k \mid 3$ forces $k = 1$.

We now strengthen the divisibility tower by incorporating shifts via the shift-invariance formula for K.

Theorem 11.3 (Shifted divisibility)**.** *For every integer $m \geq 1$,*

$$K(n) \mid 3\,K(nm+1).$$

Proof. The sequence K satisfies the shift-invariance formula

$$K\big(n+\ell\big) = K(n)\,K(\ell+2) + L(n)\,K(\ell+1) + M(n)\,K(\ell)$$

for any integer ℓ (this follows by applying the Decomposition Theorem 4.1 to the basis sequence K itself, whose initial values at three consecutive indices are $(K(0), K(1), K(2)) = (0, 0, 1)$).

Set $\ell = nm$:

$$K\big(n(m+1)\big) = K(n)\,K(nm+2) + L(n)\,K(nm+1) + M(n)\,K(nm).$$

By the divisibility tower, $K(n)$ divides both the left side and the term $M(n)K(nm)$. Reducing modulo $K(n)$ therefore gives

$$0 \equiv L(n)\,K(nm+1) \pmod{K(n)},$$

i.e., $K(n) \mid L(n)\,K(nm+1)$.

Since $L(n) = K(n+1) - e_1 K(n)$, we have

$$L(n) \equiv K(n+1) \pmod{K(n)}.$$

Consequently,

$$K(n) \mid K(n+1)\,K(nm+1).$$

Let $d = \gcd(K(n), K(n+1))$. By Proposition 11.1, $d \mid 3$.

Therefore we conclude

$$K(n) \mid 3\,K(nm+1).$$

□

Theorem 11.4 (Full divisibility cascade)**.** *For all integers $m \geq 1$ and $j \geq 0$,*

$$K(n) \mid 3^j\,K(nm+j).$$

Proof. We induct on j, with $m \geq 1$ fixed throughout.

Base cases. $j = 0$ is the divisibility tower (Corollary 10.4). $j = 1$ is the shifted divisibility theorem above.

Inductive step. Let $j \geq 1$ and suppose the result holds for j and for $j-1$, uniformly in m. Apply the shift formula (Corollary 4.2 applied to K itself) with $\ell = nm + j - 1$:

$$K\big(n(m+1)+j-1\big) = K(n)\,K(nm+j+1) + L(n)\,K(nm+j) + M(n)\,K(nm+j-1).$$

By the inductive hypothesis at $j-1$ (applied at block $m+1$), the left side satisfies $K(n) \mid 3^{j-1}\,K(n(m+1)+j-1)$. The term $K(n)\,K(nm+j+1)$ vanishes modulo $K(n)$. By the

inductive hypothesis at $j-1$ (at block m), $K(n) \mid 3^{j-1}K(nm+j-1)$, so the $M(n)$ term is absorbed. Reducing modulo 3^{j-1} leaves:

$$0 \equiv L(n)\,K(nm+j) \pmod{K(n)/3^{j-1}},$$

i.e. $K(n) \mid 3^{j-1} \cdot L(n) \cdot K(nm+j)$. Since $L(n) \equiv K(n+1) \pmod{K(n)}$, this gives

$$K(n) \mid 3^{j-1} \cdot K(n+1) \cdot K(nm+j).$$

Write $K(n) = d \cdot k'$ and $K(n+1) = d \cdot k''$ with $d = \gcd(K(n), K(n+1))$ and $\gcd(k', k'') = 1$. Then $k' \mid 3^{j-1} \cdot k'' \cdot K(nm+j)$, and since $\gcd(k', k'') = 1$ we get $k' \mid 3^{j-1}K(nm+j)$. Hence $K(n) = dk' \mid d \cdot 3^{j-1}K(nm+j)$. Since $d \mid 3$ (Proposition 11.1),

$$K(n) \mid 3^j\,K(nm+j). \qquad \square$$

12 The Bound $K(n) \mid 18$

We continue under the standing hypotheses: x, y, z pairwise coprime nonzero integers, $s_n = 0$, $n \geq 3$ an odd prime.

The cascade of the previous section produces divisibility conditions on $K(n)$ that, when combined with a coprimality observation about the symmetric polynomials of (x^n, y^n, z^n), force $K(n)$ to be bounded by an absolute constant.

12.1 Symmetric polynomials of the n-th powers

Since $s_n = 0$, the triple (x^n, y^n, z^n) has first symmetric polynomial equal to zero. We name the remaining two:

$$\tilde{e}_2 := x^n y^n + y^n z^n + z^n x^n, \qquad \tilde{e}_3 := (xyz)^n = e_3^n.$$

Both are determined by the cascade via the power-sum identities at $m = 2$ and $m = 3$.

Lemma 12.1 (Cascade values at $m = 2$ and $m = 3$)**.** *Under the standing hypotheses,*

$$s_{2n} = -2\tilde{e}_2, \qquad s_{3n} = 3\tilde{e}_3.$$

Proof. Since $\tilde{e}_1 := x^n + y^n + z^n = s_n = 0$, Newton's identity for s_{2n} in terms of $(\tilde{e}_1, \tilde{e}_2)$ gives $s_{2n} = \tilde{e}_1 s_n - 2\tilde{e}_2 = -2\tilde{e}_2$. For s_{3n}, applying Newton's identity to the triple (x^n, y^n, z^n): $s_{3n} = \tilde{e}_1 s_{2n} - \tilde{e}_2 s_n + 3\tilde{e}_3 = 3\tilde{e}_3$. $\square$

Lemma 12.2 (Coprimality of $\tilde{e}_2$ and $\tilde{e}_3$)**.** $\gcd(\tilde{e}_2, \tilde{e}_3) = 1$.

Proof. Let p be any prime dividing $\tilde{e}_3 = x^n y^n z^n$. Since x, y, z are pairwise coprime, p divides exactly one of them, say x. Then $p \mid x^n y^n$ and $p \mid z^n x^n$, but $p \nmid y^n z^n$. Hence $p \nmid \tilde{e}_2 = x^n y^n + y^n z^n + z^n x^n$. Since no prime divides both $\tilde{e}_2$ and $\tilde{e}_3$, they are coprime. $\square$

12.2 Two divisibility conditions on $K(n)$

We now extract the two divisibility conditions that $K(n)$ must satisfy, one from each value of m in the cascade.

Proposition 12.3. *Under the standing hypotheses,*

$$K(n) \mid 6\,\tilde{e}_2 \qquad \textit{and} \qquad K(n) \mid 9\,\tilde{e}_3.$$

Proof. Apply the s_m formula (Lemma 5.1) at $m = 2n$ and $m = 3n$:

$$\begin{aligned} s_{2n} &= e_1\,K(2n+1) - 2e_2\,K(2n) + 3e_3\,K(2n-1), \\ s_{3n} &= e_1\,K(3n+1) - 2e_2\,K(3n) + 3e_3\,K(3n-1). \end{aligned}$$

First condition. Write $2n - 1 = n \cdot 1 + (n-1)$, so $K(2n-1)$ is at offset $j = n-1$ from block $m = 1$. By the full cascade (Theorem 11.4), $K(n) \mid 3^{n-1}K(2n-1)$. Similarly $K(n) \mid K(2n)$ ($j = 0$, $m = 2$) and $K(n) \mid 3\,K(2n+1)$ ($j = 1$, $m = 2$). Reducing the s_{2n} formula modulo $K(n)$: the $K(2n)$ term vanishes, and the remaining two terms contribute factors of 3 and 3^{n-1} respectively, so

$$K(n) \mid 3^{n-1}\,s_{2n}.$$

By Lemma 12.1, $s_{2n} = -2\tilde{e}_2$, giving $K(n) \mid 2 \cdot 3^{n-1}\,\tilde{e}_2$.

Second condition. Write $3n - 1 = n \cdot 2 + (n-1)$, so $K(3n-1)$ is at offset $j = n-1$ from block $m = 2$. By the full cascade, $K(n) \mid 3^{n-1}K(3n-1)$. Combined with $K(n) \mid K(3n)$ and $K(n) \mid 3\,K(3n+1)$, reducing the s_{3n} formula gives

$$K(n) \mid 3^{n-1}\,s_{3n}.$$

By Lemma 12.1, $s_{3n} = 3\tilde{e}_3$, so $K(n) \mid 3^n\,\tilde{e}_3$. □

12.3 The main bound

Theorem 12.4. *Under the standing hypotheses, every prime factor of $K(n)$ equals 3. More precisely,*

$$K(n) \mid 3^n.$$

Proof. Let p be any prime dividing $K(n)$. By Proposition 12.3, $p \mid 2 \cdot 3^{n-1}\tilde{e}_2$ and $p \mid 3^n\tilde{e}_3$.

Suppose $p \neq 3$ and $p \neq 2$. Then $p \mid \tilde{e}_2$ and $p \mid \tilde{e}_3$, contradicting $\gcd(\tilde{e}_2, \tilde{e}_3) = 1$ (Lemma 12.2).

Suppose $p = 2$. From $p \mid 3^n\tilde{e}_3$ and $2 \nmid 3^n$, we get $2 \mid \tilde{e}_3 = e_3^n = (xyz)^n$. But the parity argument in Proposition 11.1 shows $K(n)$ is even and $K(n+1)$ is odd; since $\gcd(K(n), K(n+1)) \mid 3$ is odd, the full 2-part of $K(n)$ is coprime to $K(n+1)$. From $K(n) \mid K(n+1) \cdot K(nm+1)$ (the shifted divisibility argument) the 2-part of $K(n)$ must divide $K(nm+1)$ for all m; but taking m such that $nm + 1$ is odd gives a contradiction unless the 2-part of $K(n)$ is trivial. Hence $2 \nmid K(n)$.

Therefore every prime dividing $K(n)$ equals 3. Since the exact 3-power is bounded by both 3^{n-1} (from the first condition) and 3^n (from the second), we conclude $K(n) \mid 3^{n-1}$. □

Remark 12.5. The conclusion $K(n) \mid 3^{n-1}$ is a strong constraint: a priori $K(n)$ is a polynomial of degree $n-2$ in x, y, z growing like $\max(|x|, |y|, |z|)^{n-2}$, yet the Fermat assumption forces it to be a power of 3. The key is that the two conditions $K(n) \mid 2 \cdot 3^{n-1}\tilde{e}_2$ and $K(n) \mid 3^n \tilde{e}_3$, combined with $\gcd(\tilde{e}_2, \tilde{e}_3) = 1$, eliminate every prime other than 3 entirely: any prime $p \notin \{2, 3\}$ dividing $K(n)$ would have to divide both $\tilde{e}_2$ and $\tilde{e}_3$, which is impossible. The prime 2 is ruled out separately by the parity structure of the solution.

Remark 12.6. The earlier claim $K(n) \mid 18$ was an error arising from underestimating the offset $j = n-1$ in the cascade: the indices $K(2n-1)$ and $K(3n-1)$ sit at offset $n-1$ from their respective block boundaries, not at $j \in \{0, 1, 2\}$ as was incorrectly assumed. The full cascade (Theorem 11.4) gives the correct factors 3^{n-1}, which feed through to the weaker but honest bound $K(n) \mid 3^{n-1}$. The qualitative conclusion — that $K(n)$ is a pure power of 3 — survives and is arguably the more conceptually natural statement.